

How to succeed in a group project

In COMP1531 and beyond 🚀

COMP1531 – Software Engineering Fundamentals

About Rani

- Experienced COMP1531 tutor (3 years 🧓)
- Interned at range of companies: Deloitte, Westpac, Google
- Involved in many student-led group-based activities
 - CSESoc Careers Director
 - Started my own society w/ friends
 - BITSA, WIT, UMCG, ...
- Experienced slacker and high-performing leader
- 💖 Unironically love group work 💖

And yes, my friends have called me insane for this opinion.

Why teamwork?

Why teamwork?

- One of THE most important skills
- Make success better than “random chance”

We will cover:

Planning out Tasks

- How to run an effective meeting?
- How to plan out and assign your tasks?
- How to keep up-to-date with progress?

Development & Review

- How to make sure people get their work done on time?
- How to be a better contributor?
- How to make sure people get work done to a high standard?

Conflict Management

- How to plan for conflict (group contract)?
- How to make decisions as a group?
- How to manage internal conflict?
- Teamwork evaluation

Disclaimer: these strategies are NOT compulsory.

Planning

How to run a meeting that isn't a huge waste of time

Types of meetings

- Kick-off meeting
- Weekly status update meetings
- Daily stand-ups
- Decision making meetings
- Design reviews
- Debrief Meetings

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- **Kick-off meeting**
- Weekly status update meetings
- **Daily stand-ups**
- Decision making meetings
- Design reviews
- Debrief Meetings

Meeting Minutes

Meeting X	
Date/time	
Week	
Attendees	

Agenda

Item	Discussion/decision

Action Items/reminders

☐ Task

Questions for tutor

- Q1

- This is the level of complexity that your marker expects
- A markdown template has been provided
 - You don't have to use markdown
 - Use any tool you wish, to create your minutes
 - But it must end up timestamped on your GitLab project-backend repo

- **GANTT Charts**
- Visualise task scheduling
- Communicate dependencies
- Allow for progress tracking
- Not necessary in this course



Planning for Dependencies

- Plan for dependencies

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Each iteration will have a list to implement:

- clear
- adminAuthRegister
- adminUserDetails
- adminQuizCreate
- adminQuizList
- adminQuizNameUpdate
- , etc

Planning for Dependencies

- Plan for dependencies

Is there an order?

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Yes, some functions rely on others to test.

Planning for Dependencies

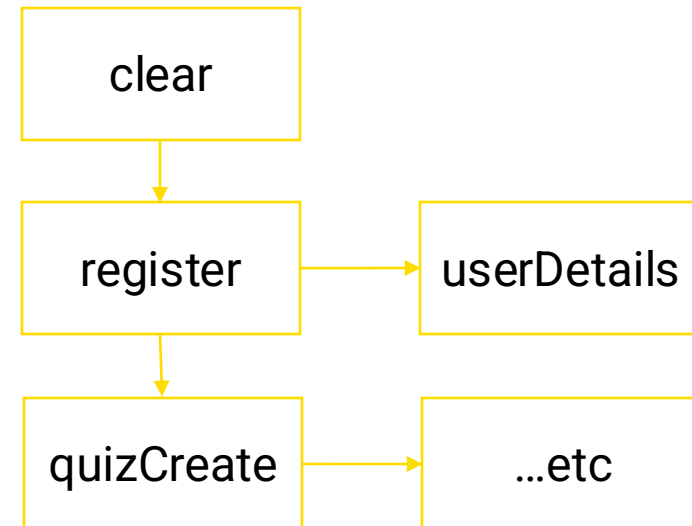
- Plan for dependencies →
dependencies graph

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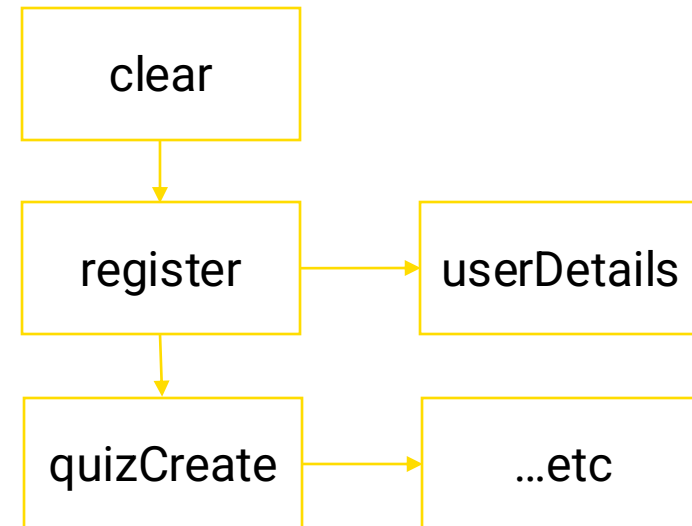
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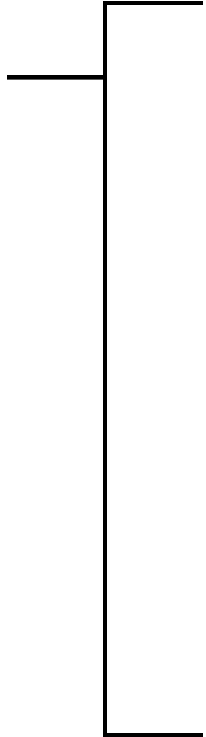
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* break up any circular dependencies

How to distribute tasks fairly

- Assign specific roles
 - **Not all tasks require high technical competence**
 - However, in COMP1531, documentation contribution is not a substitute for code contribution
- 
- Project management
 - Sending out reminders of upcoming deadlines
 - User Interface Design
 - Brainstorming Test Cases
 - Usability testing
 - Writing Documentation
 - Report writing – executive summary, intro, conclusion, etc
 - Reviewing the Specification

How to distribute tasks fairly

- Assign specific roles
- Not all tasks require high technical competence
- **Verbal agreements of equity**

Is everyone happy with their tasks?

Are you comfortable with this workload?

Does that seem fair?

Task Board

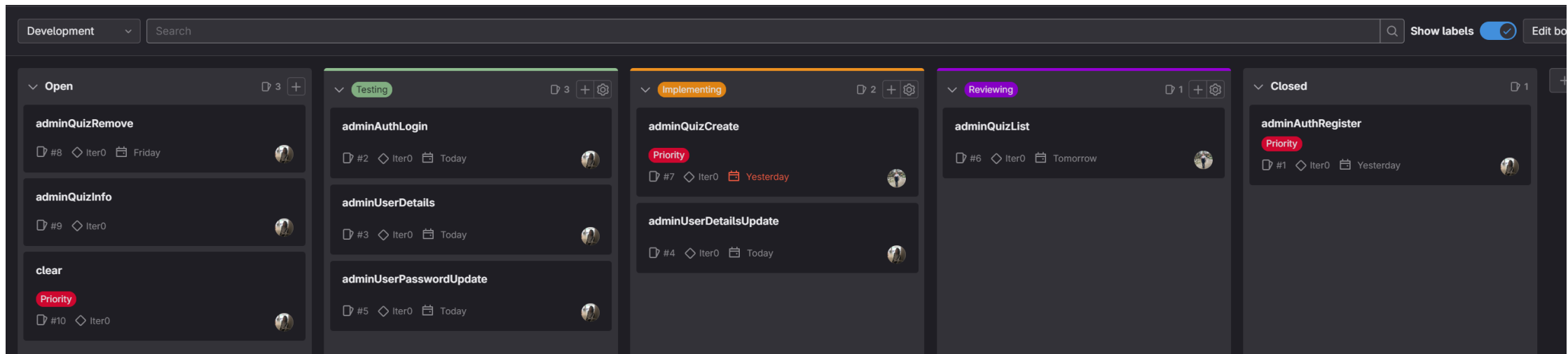
- Understand Progress → Task Board

Task Board

- Understand Progress → Task Board
- Project MGMT tool to track tasks: description, status, assignee

Task Board

- Understand Progress → Task Board
- Project MGMT tool to track tasks: description, status, assignee
- Progress at a glance



Simpler Layout

To Do, Doing, Done

The image shows a Kanban board interface with a dark theme. At the top, there's a header bar with a 'Development' dropdown, a search bar, and buttons for 'Show labels', 'Edit board', and a share icon. The main workspace is divided into four columns: 'Open', 'To Do', 'Doing', and 'Closed'. The 'Open' column is empty. The 'To Do' column has a red 'Bug' label. The 'Doing' column is empty. The 'Closed' column contains four items, each with a title, labels, and a status. The first item is 'Documentation: Requirements and Design' with labels 'Documentation' and 'Ready for review'. The second is 'HTTP test comments' with labels 'Doing' and 'Style'. The third is 'Iteration 2 feedback' with label 'To Do'. The fourth is 'user/profile/uploadphoto' with labels 'Extra' and 'Feature'. A right sidebar titled 'Issue details' shows information for the first item, including its title, assignee (Alvin Cherk), milestone (Iteration 3), time tracking, due date (Jun 7, 2024), labels (Documentation, Ready for review), confidentiality (Not confidential), and notifications (checked).

Development Search Show labels Edit board

Open To Do Doing Closed

Documentation: Requirements and Design
Documentation Ready for review
#94 Iteration 3 Friday

HTTP test comments
Doing Style
#91 Iteration 3

Iteration 2 feedback
To Do
#90 Iteration 3

user/profile/uploadphoto
Extra Feature
#88 Iteration 3

message/unreact implementation and tests
Feature Read description
#80 Iteration 3

Issue details
Add a to do

Documentation: Requirements and Design
COMP1531/20T3/groups/thu13mango3/p
Edit

Assignee
Alvin Cherk
Edit

Milestone
Iteration 3 (expired)
Edit

Time tracking
No estimate or time spent
+

Due date
Jun 7, 2024 - remove due date
Edit

Labels
Documentation Ready for review
Edit

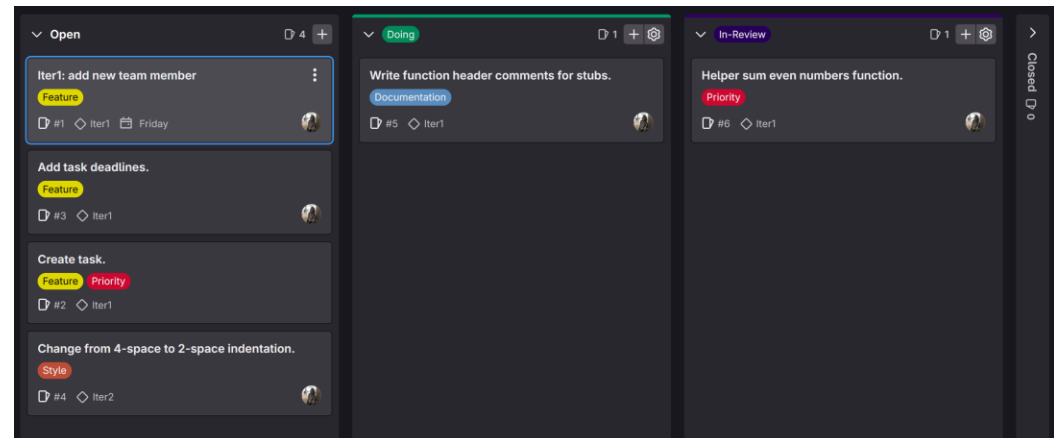
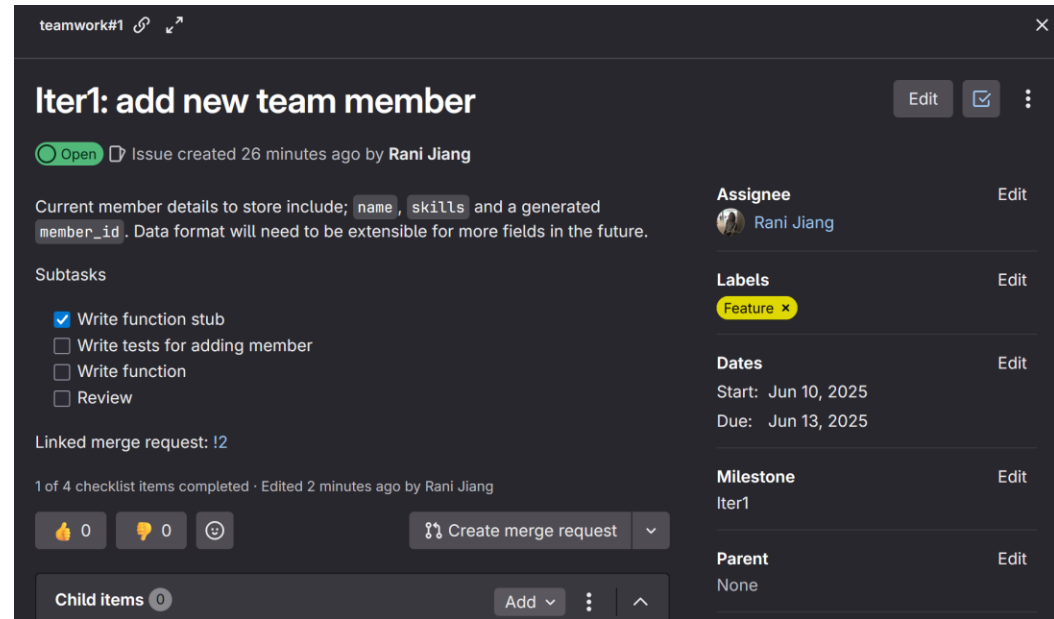
Confidentiality
Not confidential
Edit

Notifications
✓

Task Board

Course expectations:

- Assignee/s
- Brief title
- Description
 - with subtasks and/or implementation details
- Clear iteration for task
 - E.g. through a title prefix “iter0: ... task”, or milestone, or label
- Progression through at least 3 stages.
 - e.g. todo, in-progress, in-review, done



Development

Frequent Check-Ins

- Frequent check-ins
- An iteration is ~two weeks...
- Meetings are too long
- What else can we do?

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 - What did I do?
 - What problems did I face? (Blockers)
 - What am I going to do?

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 - sync: in real-time e.g. stand up in-person
 - async: not in real-time e.g. via email

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 - What problems am I facing? (Blockers)
- Can be synchronous or asynchronous
 - sync: in real-time e.g. stand up in-person
 - async: not in real-time e.g. via email
- Course expectations: **2 standups per week** from each member.

Example *Async* Standup

Rani Jiang Yesterday 12:34 am Edited

Iteration 2 - Week 6 Monday Standup

Hi team! Leave a quick comment describing:

- 🐱 What you've done?
- 🧱 What are your blockers?
- 🎮 What you're going to do?

Anything else you want to add - doesn't need to be project related 😊

Rani Jiang Yesterday 12:38 am Edited

What I've Done

- I've completed `adminAuthRegister` ! Merge request is ready [here](#).
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Blockers

- I can't properly test `adminQuizNameUpdate` until [Alvin](#) has finished `adminQuizCreate` 🐱
- Struggling a bit with jest testing... and have other course work coming up soon FYI

What I'm going to do

- Finish `adminAuthLogin` tests and work on `adminQuizNameUpdate` ~

Hope you guys had a good weekend 🤗

[see less](#)



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Hi Team!

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UNSW
SYDNEY

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🙏 1



How to make sure people get their work done on time

1. Always set deadlines

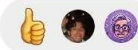
Hey Sam, considering that you have experience with 3D modelling, do you mind making a model of the enclosure?

How to make sure people get their work done on time

1. Always set deadlines
2. **Avoid the social diffusion effect**

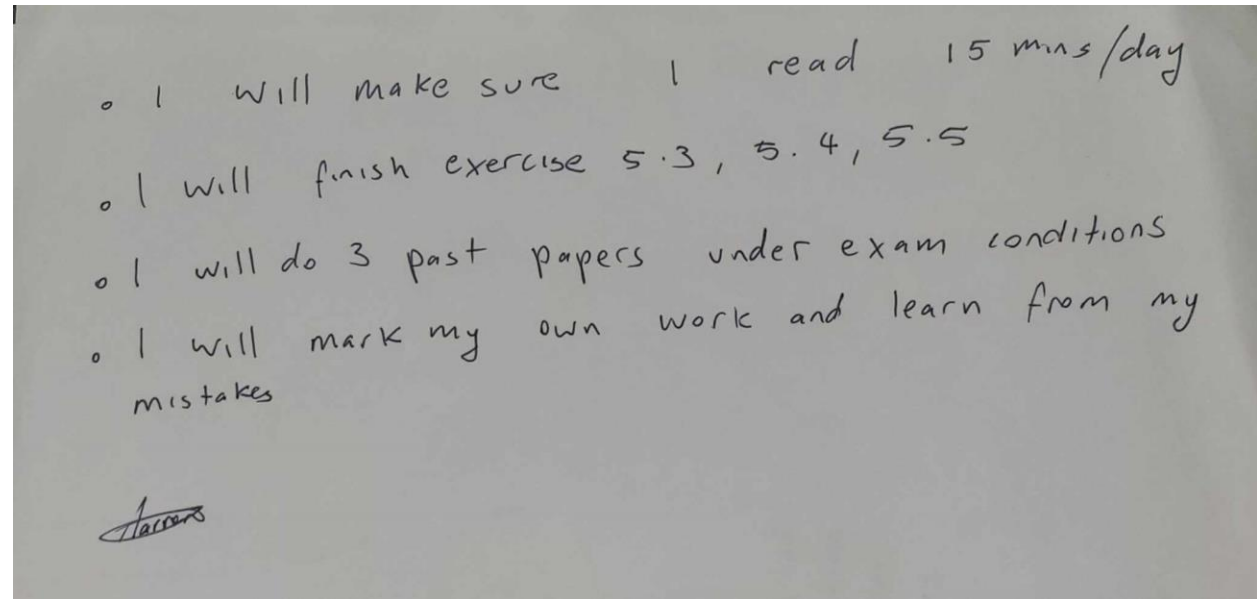
Hey team, here is a summary of the tasks for this week. Please complete by next Tuesday's meeting.

- Mary/Jason: Write up the "Justification for Design Decisions" section of the final report



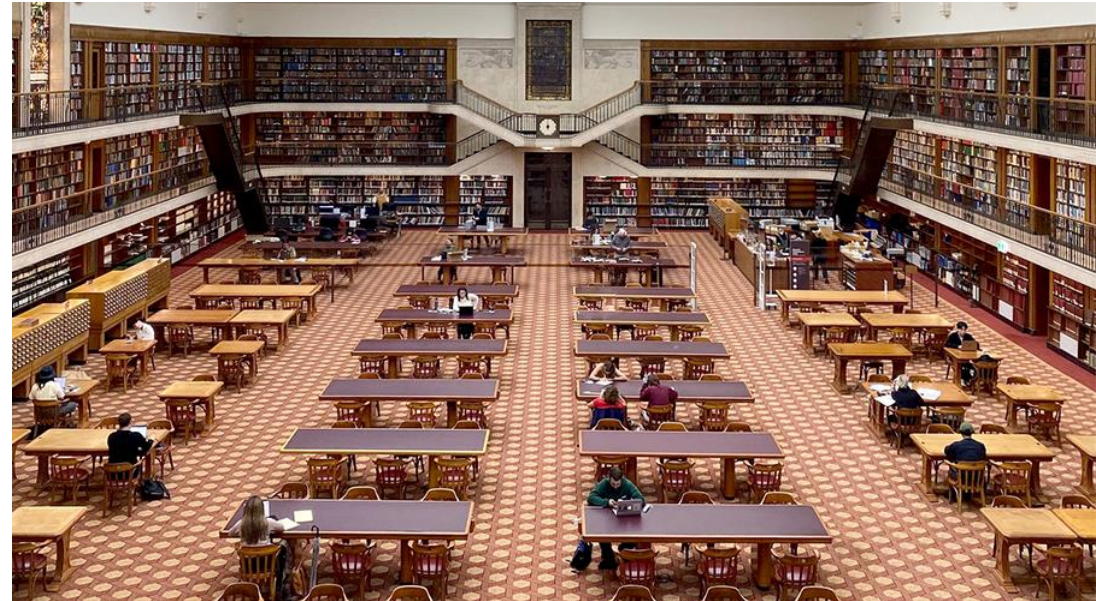
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3. **Exploit commitment bias**



How to make sure people get their work done on time

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4. **Exploit the social facilitation effect**



How to make sure people get their work done on time

1. Always set deadlines
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4. Exploit the social facilitation effect
5. **A team will not lead itself**

Roles of team leader:

- Setting goals
- Delegate tasks
- Plan timeline
- Facilitate communication
- Motivate and support
- Monitor progress
- Mediate conflict

How to make sure people get their work done on time

1. Always set deadlines
2. Avoid the social diffusion effect
3. Exploit commitment bias
4. Exploit the social facilitation effect
5. Check in regularly and send reminders
6. **A team will not lead itself**

A team leader does not have to:

- Have the best technical skills
- Be a dictator
- Have a higher workload than everyone else
- Start fights with people
- Be the most experienced / authoritative member

How to be a better contributor?

Optional, but recommended.

- **Be transparent and proactive.**
If things aren't going well, tell the group. If you aren't going to get a task done on time, tell the group. Start tasks earlier to get feedback.
- **Embrace imposter syndrome.**
Don't shy away from a task just because you aren't 100% sure you can do it. You'll learn along the way.
- **80/20 Rule.**
80% your marks can be achieved from 20% of your effort. Put your time where it will make the greatest impact.
- **Practice, practice, practice.**
Technical skills don't develop overnight. Keep up to date with content. Trying, understand and modify.
- **Break the problem down.**
Any problem can be solved when broken down and attacked one small piece at a time. Create a minimum reproducible example.
- **Make use of resources.**
It's important to try yourself first. But don't stop there. Search online, read others code or pair program, go to help sessions and ask on the forum.

Review

Definition of Completion

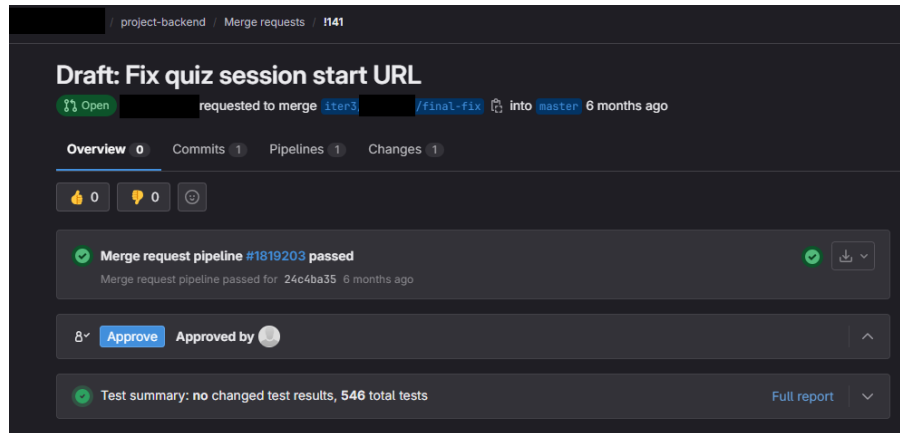
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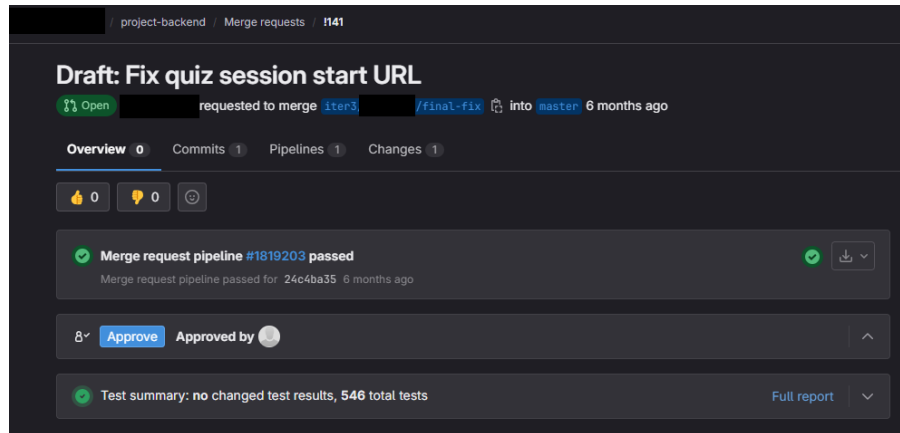
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Merge Request
1-click away from merging

Definition of Completion

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Merge Request
1-click away from merging

```
$ git status
On branch master
Your branch is up to date with 'origin/master'.

Changes to be committed:
  (use "git restore --staged <file>..." to unstage)
        new file:   finishedv2.js

Untracked files:
  (use "git add <file>..." to include in what will be committed)
        half-done-work.png
```

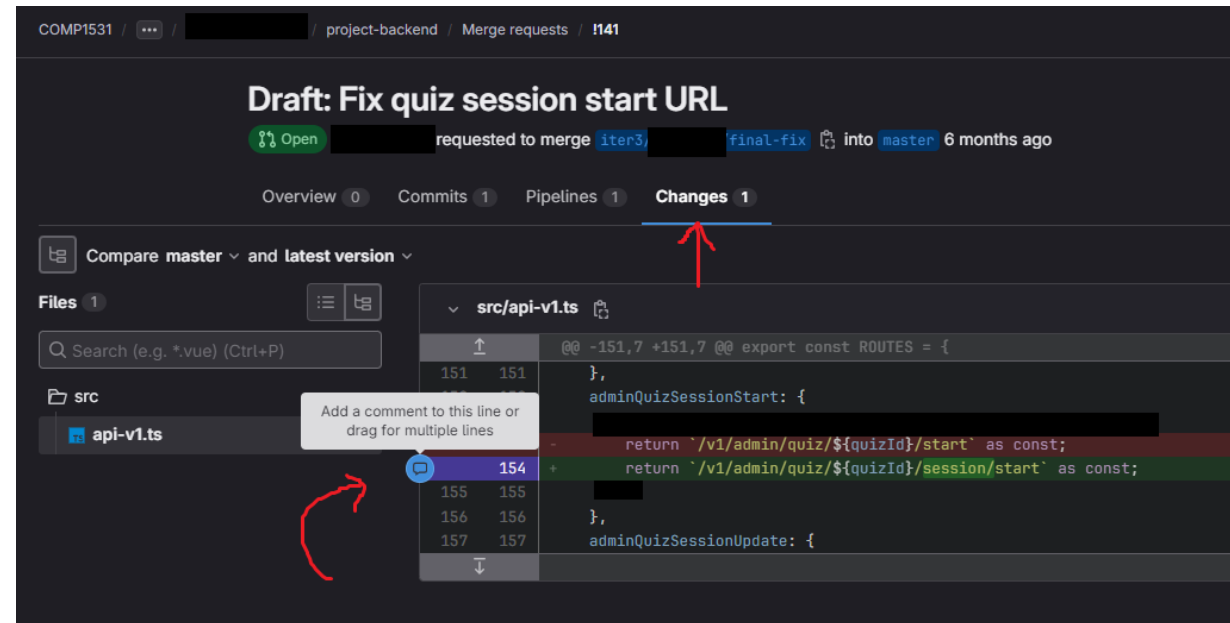
Local Code
untested, unreviewed, ready to rumble

Tasks done to a high standard

- Code Review
- Pair Programming
- Setting git specific standards

Code Review

- Quality assurance process
- Different types: sync, async
- Benefits:
 - Share knowledge
 - Discover bugs earlier
 - Maintain standards
 - Improve code quality
- No single point of failure



Example: Code Review

JS helper.js 409 B

```
1 function sum_even_numbers(nums) {  
2     var sum = 0;  
3  
4     for (let i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {  
5         if (nums[i] % 2 == 0)  
6         {  
7             sum += nums[i]  
8         }  
9     }  
10  
11     return sum;  
12 }  
13  
14 let positive = [1,2,3,4,5];  
15 const negative = [-1,-2,-3,-4,-5];  
16 let mixed = [0,1,-1,2,-2,3,-3];  
17  
18 console.log(sum_even_numbers(positive));  
19 console.log(sum_even_numbers(negative));  
20 console.log(sum_even_numbers(mixed));  
21
```

Example: Code Review

JS helper.js 409 B

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7       sum += nums[i]
8     }
9   }
10
11   return sum;
12 }
13
14 let positive = [1,2,3,4,5];
15 const negative = [-1,-2,-3,-4,-5];
16 let mixed = [0,1,-1,2,-2,3,-3];
17
18 console.log(sum_even_numbers(positive));
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```

Added basic sumEvenNumbers function

Open Rani Jiang requested to merge iterX/sumEvenNumbers into master 15 minutes ago

Overview 5 Commits 1 Pipelines 2 Changes 1

src/auth.js 0 → 100644

1 + function sumEvenNumbers(numbers) {

Z Alvin Cherk @z5311001 · 7 minutes ago

Maybe add some JSDoc comments so that it is easier to read and understand. For example @z5205677, you can try this:

```
/**
 * Sums even numbers
 * @param { number[] } numbers array of numbers
 * @returns sum of even numbers
 */
function sumEvenNumbers(numbers) {
```

Also, you should probably use `const = sumEvenNumbers = (numbers) => {` to be consistent with the rest of the codebase

Reply...

Start another thread

2 + var sum = 0;

Z Alvin Cherk @z5311001 · 7 minutes ago

Why use `var` here? Why not just `let`

Reply...

Start another thread

3 +
4 + for (let i = 0; i < numbers.length; i++) {

Z Alvin Cherk @z5311001 · 7 minutes ago

Is there a reason why we are using a for index based loop?

These loops are inherently dangerous because we are indexing. We can avoid this entirely, by refactoring it into a for-of loop.

For example:

```
for (const number of numbers) {
```

You could also use a reducer if you want to look cool. See the documentation [here](#)

Reply...



Pair Programming

- Two developers, one monitor and keyboard – working together
- Fosters knowledge sharing, real time code review, increase collaboration

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Unstructured

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In the driver/navigator approach to pair programming, one developer sets the architectural or strategic direction, and the other implements these decisions as code.

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Ping-pong

Ping-pong pair programming shifts rapidly back-and-forth between the two developers, like a game of ping pong, where the software is the ball.

Create Internal Standards

- READ THE MARKING CRITERIA
 - If the marking criteria is too vague, add specificity yourself

Create Internal Standards

- READ THE MARKING CRITERIA
 - If the marking criteria is too vague, add specificity yourself
- All commits follow some format e.g.
“test: added login tests”
- All branches start with iteration e.g.
“iter1/adminAuthLogin”
- All merge requests follow the process:
 - Original author is the assignee
 - Another team member reviews
 - Original author merges

As an individual, in terms of git:

- For particular features, committing the bulk of your tests prior to your implementation.
- Your git commit messages are meaningful, clear, and informative.
- You contribute at least 2 meaningful merge requests (approved by a team member) that merge your branch code to master.

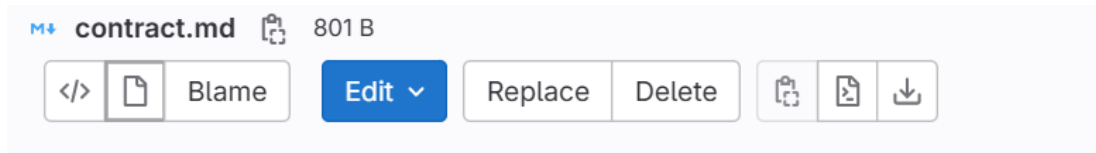
git Marking Criteria

Conflict Management

Most common causes of arguments

- Strong, conflicting opinions
 - Design decisions
- People not willing to listen to others
- People not getting a chance to share their ideas
- Having different rules for acceptable behaviour
- Workload not being shared equally
- Not having clear rules about when and where to communicate
- People not attending meetings / doing work on time

Group contract



Group:

zID	Name

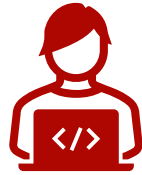
- Assessed in iteration 0
- Use the template in the repo

1. When and where will we schedule meetings (e.g. 11am Wednesdays and 2pm Fridays: in-person at X location, on Teams video call, on Discord)?
2. Where will we record our meeting minutes (e.g. Teams documents, Gitlab Wiki, Gitlab markdown file)?
3. Where will we communicate (e.g. Teams channel, Discord, Messenger)?
4. What is a reasonable response time for messages/posts when communicating?
5. How will we handle conflicts (i.e. differing opinions)? Note: If conflicts cannot resolved this way, please contact your tutor.
6. List the steps a team member does if they get stuck (e.g. can't meet a deadline or stuck debugging).

How to make Decisions as a Group!



Which kanban
board should we
use?



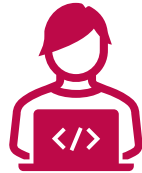
Jira!



Gitlab Issues!



Gitlab Issues!



Gitlab Issues!



Gitlab Issues!

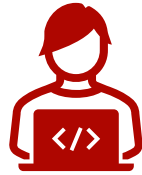


Gitlab Issues!

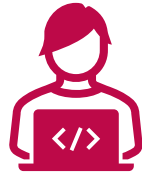
How to make Decisions as a Group!



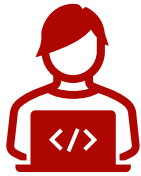
Which kanban board should we use?



I know everyone wants to use Gitlab Issues, but do you mind if I share why I think Jira is better?



How to make Decisions as a Group!



Let's use an
array of objects!



No, let's use a
single object!



No, let's use
multiple arrays!

How to make Decisions as a Group!



Let's call the
variable `data`



No, let's call it
`dataStore`

What to do if someone is slacking off

- Understand the root cause:
 - Procrastination
 - Lack of intrinsic motivation
 - Have a private, candid conversation with them
 - Give them tasks that they genuinely enjoy
 - Misunderstanding of deadline importance
 - Emphasise the consequences of missing the deadline
 - Overwhelming task size
 - Break big tasks up into smaller tasks, which are checked up on each week
 - Personal issues
 - Give their tasks to other team members
 - Offer them support
 - Heavy workload from other courses
 - Very rarely valid

Conflict Management

- Internal group issue? E.g. unequal contribution, merging bad code, rude

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- Disappearing group members?
 - Message them on MS Teams asking them for their whereabouts
 - If they don't reply in 48-72 hours, continue as if they won't reappear
 - If they reappear and have lost the opportunity to work – that's on them
 - Avoid putting yourself in life-or-death situations waiting for a reply within 48 hours

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- Communicate clearly with your team and your tutor.
- NOTE: Tutors check for contribution via peer evaluation, scripts, git.

Contribution & Teamwork Evaluation

- For iter1+ (not iter0)
- Teamwork Evaluation
 - Participation
 - Dependability
 - Team Wellbeing
 - Work Contribution
 - Comment
- Reviewed by your tutor

1. Participation

Think about the recent iteration 1.

What was each team member's level of participation in group work, attendance at meetings, marking suggestions and taking responsibility for tasks, being in communication with the team?

The expected level of performance for a normal, hard working team member is 4-5.

z5030786 Jiang, Yuchao	3 - Below expectations
z5205677 Jiang, Rani	1 - Not active member
z5313514 Nguyen, Tam	7 - Superhero
z5417857 Worboys, Ned	1 - Not active member
z5480561 Chou, Amber	2 - Minimum required
z5482828 Wang, Junya	3 - Below expectations
	4 - Good team member
	5 - High level of performance
	6 - Beyond expectations
	✓ 7 - Superhero

2. Dependability

Think about the recent iteration 1.

How dependable was each team member in delivering assigned tasks on time with expected levels of quality?

The expected level of performance for a normal, hard working team member is level 4 or 5.

Group & Individual Reflection

- For iter1+ (not iter0)
- Individual Reflection
 - Reflection of work done
 - Individual improvements for next iteration
- Group Reflection
 - Distribution of work
 - Reflection on group processes for next iteration
- Reviewed by your tutor during the project demo

End of Iteration Individual Reflection

Iteration: ____

Date: ____

Answer briefly (dot points are fine):

1. What are the 2-3 most valuable contributions you made this iteration? (link issues/PRs)
2. What went well in how you worked? (planning, communication, code quality, collaboration)
3. What could you improve next time? (skills, habits, process)

Iteration 1 Reflection

Note: you may refer to your group contract during this reflection. It is natural to add/remove/edit requirements as you progress through the project.

zID	Name

Who worked on what functions for this iteration?

What went well for your group this iteration?

What didn't go well for your group this iteration?

What could you do better next iteration?

Do you need to
do everything we've
mentioned?

No!

No! Marking Criteria is Flexible

- The marking criteria expects a minimum standard of
 - meeting notes/minutes
 - issues board
 - standups

As an individual, in terms of project management and teamwork:

- Attendance to group check ins every week.
- Effective use of course-provided MS Teams for effective communication with your group.
- Use of issue board on Gitlab OR another equivalent tool that is used to effectively track your tasks.
- Attendance and contributions at your teams standups, including at least one scenario where you were the leader of the meeting and took the minutes/notes for that meeting.

Project Marking Criteria

No! Marking Criteria is Flexible

- The marking criteria expects a minimum standard of
 - meeting notes/minutes
 - issues board
 - standups
- Your group might impose additional standards
- Pick and choose relevant strategies effective for your group

As an individual, in terms of project management and teamwork:

- Attendance to group check ins every week.
- Effective use of course-provided MS Teams for effective communication with your group.
- Use of issue board on Gitlab OR another equivalent tool that is used to effectively track your tasks.
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Project Marking Criteria

Questions?

Past Questions

- Communicating in a 2nd language?
- Communicating with an age gap? Or knowledge gap?
- Reconciling different individual goals? e.g. HD vs Pass

Thanks for Listening!

End.